

Exhaustivity without strong uniqueness: Specificational and cleft-like *là* in Vietnamese

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1 Introduction

Vietnamese *là* has traditionally been described as a copular element, but its distribution and interpretation suggest that identificationality and strong exhaustivity are not uniformly linked. In addition to appearing in ordinary predication clauses, *là* also occurs in specificational clauses and in constructions that resemble exhaustive focus or cleft constructions. This paper focuses on a puzzle concerning Vietnamese specificational *là*. In English, specificational clauses such as (1) strongly imply singleton uniqueness: the sentence identifies a single individual as satisfying the relevant description.

- (1) The teacher is Nam.

Under ordinary interpretations, (1) suggests that Nam is the only teacher under discussion. Additive continuations are therefore infelicitous.

- (2) #The teacher is Nam, and also Lan.

Vietnamese appears to behave differently. Although Vietnamese specificational clauses resemble English specificational clauses in expressing identificational relations, they do not consistently enforce strict singleton interpretations.

- (3) Giáo viên là Nam.
teacher LA N.
'The teacher is Nam.'

Unlike English, sentences such as (3) may allow additive continuations in appropriate contexts.

- (4) ?Giáo viên là Nam, và cũng là Lan.
teacher LA N. and also LA L.
'The teachers are Nam and Lan.'

At the same time, other *là* constructions behave more like canonical exhaustive focus constructions.

- (5) Mỗi Nam là giáo viên.
 only N. LA teacher
 ‘Only Nam is the teacher.’

Unlike the specificational examples above, cleft-like constructions such as (5) resist additive continuations.

- (6) #Mỗi Nam là giáo viên, và Lan cũng vậy.
 only N. LA teacher, and L. also so
 Intended: ‘#Only Nam is the teacher, and Lan too.’

The contrast between (3)-(4) and (5)-(6) raises several questions. First, why do Vietnamese specificational clauses permit interpretations that appear incompatible with strong singleton uniqueness? Second, what distinguishes the interpretation of specificational *là* from that of cleft-like *là*? Third, what role does the lack of obligatory number marking in Vietnamese play in these interpretations?

The goal of this paper is not to provide a complete formal analysis of the phenomenon. Instead, I aim to provide an empirical description of the phenomenon and to show that Vietnamese specificational and cleft-like *là* constructions display distinct patterns with respect to exhaustivity and uniqueness. In particular, I observe that Vietnamese specificational clauses exhibit weaker or more defeasible uniqueness effects than those typically associated with English specificational clauses, while cleft-like *là* displays a stronger exclusion of alternatives.

The discussion proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews background issues concerning specificational clauses, exhaustivity, and cleft-like constructions. Section 3 presents the core empirical patterns involving Vietnamese *là*, focusing on additive continuations, compatibility with *mỗi* ‘only’, negation, and the role of number neutrality. Section 4 discusses the broader implications of these patterns for theories of exhaustivity and identificationality. Section 5 concludes the paper.

2 Background and theoretical issues

2.1 Specificational versus predicational clauses

A central distinction in the literature on copular sentences is that between predicational and specificational clauses. Predicational clauses express class membership or property attribution. In such cases, the post-copular predicate denotes a property, and the subject is interpreted as an individual that satisfies that property.

- (7) Nam là giáo viên.
 N. LA teacher
 ‘Nam is a teacher.’

In (7), the nominal *giáo viên* ‘teacher’ functions as a predicate, and the sentence asserts that Nam belongs to the set of teachers.

On the contrary, specificational clauses involve an identificational relation between two expressions, often analyzed as a variable-value configuration. One nominal expression introduces a discourse referent or variable, and the other supplies its value.

- (8) (repeated from (3))
 Giáo viên là Nam.
 teacher LA N.
 ‘The teacher is Nam.’

In (8), the pre-copular nominal *giáo viên* does not simply denote a property, but rather introduces a role or variable whose value is identified as Nam. Specificational clauses are therefore typically associated with identificational meaning rather than simple predication.

A well-known property of specificational clauses in languages such as English is that they tend to give rise to strong uniqueness or maximality effects. That is, the value supplied by the post-copular expression is interpreted as the unique individual that satisfies the relevant description in the discourse context.

This is reflected in the infelicity of additive continuations as seen earlier:

- (9) #The teacher is Nam, and also Lan.

However, the strength and source of this uniqueness effect remain controversial. While some approaches treat it as a semantic property of specificational structure (Higgins 1979; Mikkelsen 2005; Dikken 2006), others argue that it arises from definiteness and discourse conditions rather than from the copular construction itself (Ward and Birner 2004).

The Vietnamese facts introduced in section 1 challenge the assumption that specificational clauses necessarily enforce strict singleton uniqueness. As shown in (3)-(4), Vietnamese specificational *là* allows additive continuations under certain conditions, suggesting that the identificational relation in Vietnamese may not impose the same constraints as seen in English.

This raises two important questions for the present paper. First, to what extent do Vietnamese specificational clauses illustrate the same variable-value structure discussed in the literature? Second, if they do, why do they fail to consistently yield strong uniqueness effects? Such questions motivate a closer look at exhaustivity and identificational focus, which we now examine.

2.2 Exhaustivity and identificational focus

Exhaustivity is commonly understood as the exclusion of relevant alternatives. An expression is interpreted exhaustively when it conveys that no alternatives other than the asserted one satisfy the relevant predicate. In many languages, exhaustivity is most transparently encoded by focus-sensitive operators such as *only*.

(10) Only Nam is a teacher.

The sentence in (10) entails that no individual other than Nam is a teacher in the relevant context. This type of interpretation is often referred to as strong exhaustivity or singleton exclusivity.

A related notion is identificational focus, as discussed by Kiss (1998). Identificational focus constructions are characterized by (i) the identification of a value from a set of contextually relevant alternatives, (ii) the exclusion of all non-selected alternatives, and (iii) a structural position associated with focus interpretation.

Cleft constructions are a canonical example of identificational focus. In English, clefts such as (11) are typically interpreted exhaustively.

(11) It is Nam who is the teacher.

Like *only*-sentences, clefts strongly resist additive continuations:

(12) #It is Nam who is the teacher, and also Lan.

This similarity has led many scholars to treat clefts as encoding exhaustivity in a way comparable to *only*, though the precise mechanism remains debatable. An important question is whether exhaustivity is a uniform phenomenon. Some approaches treat it as a single operator, while others distinguish between stronger and weaker forms of exhaustivity depending on structure and context.

The Vietnamese data introduced earlier suggest that such a distinction may be necessary. While cleft-like *là* constructions behave similarly to canonical exhaustive focus constructions, Vietnamese specificational clauses do not consistently enforce the same level of exclusion. This contrast raises the possibility that what appears to be "exhaustivity" in Vietnamese may not be a single uniform phenomenon. Instead, different constructions involving *là* may give rise to distinct types of identificational or exclusion effects, differing in their strength and in how strictly they exclude alternatives.

2.3 Clefts, focus partition, and reduced cleft-like constructions

2.3.1 Canonical clefts and exhaustive focus

Cleft constructions are commonly analyzed as structures that partition a proposition into two components: a focused constituent and a presupposed background. In English, canonical *it*-clefts have the form in (13), where the focused XP appears in a copular clause and the remainder of the proposition is expressed in a relative clause.

- (13) It is Nam who bought the cake.

Following Lambrecht (2001), clefts express a logically simple proposition through a biclausal structure consisting of a matrix copular clause and a relative(-like) clause. Despite this structural complexity, clefts are interpreted exhaustively: the focused constituent is identified as the unique value satisfying the background predicate.

Canonical clefts are therefore closely related to identificational focus constructions discussed in Section 2.2. They identify one value from a contextually relevant set of alternatives while excluding non-selected alternatives. This interpretation closely parallels that of focus-sensitive operators such as *only*.

The relation between exhaustivity and cleft structure can be illustrated by comparing non-cleft and cleft configurations. Consider the English sentences in (14). Both sentences interpretively exclude alternatives to *Nam*. However, the cleft in (14-b) differs structurally from the non-cleft sentence in (14-a). In addition to expressing exhaustivity, the cleft overtly partitions the sentence into a focused constituent (*only Nam*) and a background predicate (*x bought the cake*). In this sense, clefts involve not only exclusion of alternatives, but also a particular type of information structure.

- (14) a. Only Nam bought a cake.
b. It was only Nam who bought a cake.

A relevant notion is that of reduced or cleft-like constructions, in which some of the overt material associated with canonical clefts (e.g., expletive subjects, relative morphology) is absent, while the focus-background interpretation is retained. Cross-linguistically, languages differ considerably in how explicitly cleft structure is morphologically realized.

For descriptive purposes, I refer to such constructions as "cleft-like". This term is used descriptively, without committing to any particular analysis of the underlying structure, such as full biclausality versus monoclausality. The term simply reflects the following properties: (i) a partition between a focused constituent and a background predicate, (ii) an interpretation involving exclusion of alternatives, and (iii) parallels with what is considered canonical cleft constructions in other languages.

2.3.2 Vietnamese cleft-like *là*

Vietnamese presents an interesting case in this respect. Constructions involving *là* can convey an interpretation comparable to clefts, even though they lack overt relative clause morphology and do not obviously display biclausal syntax on the surface. Instead of introducing a new structural variant, the present paper restricts attention to the cleft-like configurations already seen in Section 1. In such cases as seen in (15), the pre-*là* constituent (*mỗi Nam* ‘only Nam’) is interpreted as the focus, evaluated against a set of contextually relevant alternatives (e.g., possible buyers), while the post-*là* material expresses the background predicate, in a manner comparable to canonical clefts.

- (15) *Mỗi Nam là mua bánh.*
 only N. LA buy cake
 ‘It is only Nam who bought a cake.’

Vietnamese also allows focus on constituents other than subjects. The examples in (16)-(19) show that Vietnamese *là*-clefts are not restricted to subject focus, but may target a wide range of constituents, including direct objects, indirect objects, temporal adjuncts, and even nominalized predicates. In each case, the focused constituent appears clause-initially and is followed by *là*, while the remainder of the clause expresses the presupposed proposition. The interpretation associated with these constructions is exhaustive or contrastive: the focused constituent is always identified as the unique element satisfying the relevant proposition within the discourse context.

- (16) *Direct objects*
- a. *Mỗi bánh là Nam mua.*
 only cake LA N. buy
 ‘It was only the cake that Nam bought.’ (as opposed to other dishes that he made himself)
 - b. *Nam mua mỗi bánh.*
 N. buy only cake
 ‘Nam only bought (a) cake.’ (he did not buy anything else)
- (17) *Indirect objects*
- a. *Mỗi Mary là Nam tặng bánh.*
 only M. LA N. give cake
 ‘It was only Mary that Nam gave (a) cake to.’ (as opposed to other potential recipients)
 - b. *Nam tặng bánh cho mỗi Mary.*
 N. give cake to only Mary
 ‘Nam gave a cake to only Mary.’
- (18) *Temporal adjuncts*
- a. *Mỗi hôm qua là Nam không nộp bài tập về nhà.*
 only yesterday LA N. NEG submit homework

‘It was only yesterday that Nam didn’t submit the homework.’ (Nam usually submits homework, but yesterday is the only day he didn’t)

- b. Nam không nộp bài tập về nhà mỗi hôm qua.
 N. NEG submit homework only yesterday
 ‘Only yesterday, Nam didn’t submit homework.’

(19) *Nominalized VP?*

- a. Mỗi mua bánh là Nam chưa làm.
 only buy cake LA N NEG.PERF do
 ‘The only thing Nam hasn’t done yet is buy (a) cake.’ (as opposed to the other tasks he has done)
- b. Nam chưa làm mỗi *(khoản) mua bánh.
 N. NEG.PERF do only NMLZ.CLF buy cake
 ‘Nam only hasn’t bought a cake yet.’ / ‘Nam hasn’t done only the cake-buying thing.’

The contrast between the (a) and (b) examples further demonstrates that the cleft construction differs systematically from the canonical in-situ use of *mỗi* ‘only’. In the canonical sentences, *mỗi* associates directly with the constituent in its base-generated position, yielding ordinary constituent focus. In (19), it is noteworthy that the focused constituent corresponds not to a simple DP or adjunct, but to a nominalized VP-like expression, suggesting that Vietnamese clefts may also target event-denoting constituents once they are nominalized.

These data point out that *là*-clefts involve a dedicated left-peripheral focus structure associated with exhaustive identification, rather than reflecting the linear placement of the focus-sensitive particle *mỗi*. Furthermore, the presence of *là* introduces a more explicit focus-background partition and may give rise to stronger identificational effects. As a result, the cleft-like configurations in (15) and the (a) sentences in (16)-(19) overtly separates the focused constituent from the background predicate.

2.3.3 Cleft-like versus non-cleft exhaustive focus

Although Vietnamese non-cleft and cleft-like focus constructions may overlap in their exclusion of alternatives, they are not necessarily interchangeable across contexts. The cleft-like configuration appears more natural in contexts involving explicit contrast or correction focus, whereas the non-cleft one can be used in a less marked contrastive context where the speaker simply wants to exclude alternatives. The presence of *là* contributes not merely exhaustivity itself but also a more articulated focus-background partition.

On the other hand, the comparison between cleft-like and non-cleft focus further illustrates the role of *là* in Vietnamese exhaustive focus. Vietnamese can express exclusion using a cleft-like configuration, as in (16-a), as well as *mỗi* without *là*, as shown in (16-b). Both constructions exclude alternatives to *bánh* ‘cake’. However, the cleft-like construction differs structurally from the ordinary non-cleft sentence in that the focused constituent is separated

from the remainder of the proposition and appears in a non-canonical preverbal position. The post-là material functions as a background predicate, yielding a more explicit focus-background partition comparable to that found in canonical clefts.

Since both constructions express exclusion of alternatives, an important question arises: if Vietnamese already has ordinary only-constructions, what motivates the use of là? The difference does not appear to lie in exhaustivity alone, but rather in how the focused constituent is structurally and discourse-wise represented. This contrast becomes clearer when discourse context is taken into account. Although both constructions encode exclusion, they differ in the extent to which the relevant alternatives must already be salient in the discourse.

Consider first the object-focus constructions in (20). In contexts where alternative objects are explicitly introduced, both constructions are acceptable. In CONTEXT A in (20-a), the alternative (*trái cây* ‘fruits’) is already discourse-salient, making both the non-cleft ((20-b)) and cleft-like ((20-c)) constructions natural responses.

- (20) a. CONTEXT A:
 Hình như Nam mua bánh và trái cây đúng không?
 seem-like N. buy cake and fruit right Q
 ‘It seems that Nam bought a cake and fruits, right?’
 b. Không, Nam mua mỗi bánh.
 no N. buy only cake
 ‘No, Nam only bought cake.’
 c. Không, mỗi bánh là Nam mua.
 no only cake LA N. buy
 ‘No, it was only cake that Nam bought.’

The two constructions diverge, however, in more neutral contexts where the relevant alternatives have not yet been explicitly established. Here in (21), given CONTEXT B in (21-a), the non-cleft construction in (21-b) is natural, while the cleft-like construction in (21-c) is noticeably unacceptable. Unlike the non-cleft sentence, the cleft-like one appears to require a more explicitly established set of alternatives in the discourse.

- (21) a. CONTEXT B:
 Nam mua những gì vậy?
 N. buy PL what Q
 ‘What did Nam buy?’
 b. Nam mua mỗi bánh.
 N. buy only cake
 ‘Nam only bought cake.’
 c. #Mỗi bánh là Nam mua.
 only cake LA N. buy
 Intended: ‘It was only cake that Nam bought.’

A similar contrast is found with subject focus. Vietnamese allows both a non-cleft and a

cleft-like construction, as shown in (22-a) and (22-b). Both constructions are acceptable when the alternatives are already salient, as illustrated in (23-a). However, in a neutral question context like (23-b), once again, the non-cleft construction is acceptable while the cleft-like construction is degraded.

- (22) a. (repeated from (15))
 Mỗi Nam là mua bánh.
 only N. LA buy cake
 ‘It is only Nam who bought a cake.’
 b. Mỗi Nam mua bánh.
 only N. buy cake
 ‘Only Nam bought a cake.’
- (23) a. CONTEXT A:
 Hình như Nam và Lan đều mua bánh đúng không?
 seem N. and L. all buy cake right Q
 ‘It seems that both Nam and Lan bought cakes, right?’
 → Both (22-a) and (22-b) are acceptable.
 b. CONTEXT B:
 Những ai mua bánh vậy?
 PL who buy cake Q
 ‘Who (PL) bought cake?’
 → Only (22-b) is acceptable. (22-a) is not available for this context.

Altogether, these contrasts suggest that Vietnamese cleft-like constructions are more dependent on a discourse-salient alternative set than ordinary non-cleft *mỗi*-in-situ constructions. Although both configurations express exclusion of alternatives, the contribution of *là* in the cleft-like construction appears to extend beyond exhaustivity itself and toward a more articulated realization of focus structure.

This similarity to canonical clefts is particularly relevant from a cross-linguistic perspective. In many languages, cleft constructions are associated with A'-dependencies involving focus movement or relativization. Vietnamese differs in lacking overt *wh*- or relative morphology displaying a similarly non-canonical distribution of focused constituents, while the status of biclausality is less transparent than in English. In addition, the same morpheme *là* also appears in ordinary copular clauses and other clausal environments (elaborated in Section 2.4.2).

Despite these differences, it is clear that the Vietnamese constructions still share several core properties with English clefts. In both cases, the focused element receives an exhaustive interpretation relative to a set of alternatives. Vietnamese therefore appears to illustrate a configurational focus structure comparable to a typical cleft.

2.4 Vietnamese background

2.4.1 Number neutrality

Vietnamese nominals are not obligatorily marked for number. A bare noun such as *giáo viên* ‘teacher(s)’ can receive singular, plural, or kind readings depending on context. Unlike English, which often requires overt plural marking, Vietnamese leaves number unspecified unless it is made explicit (e.g., via numerals, classifiers, or discourse context). This matters for specificational clauses. In English, sentences like (24), repeated from (1), strongly favour a singleton reading.

(24) The teacher is Nam.

In Vietnamese, the corresponding nominal does not force singularity. This raises an important question for the present discussion: are the apparent non-uniqueness effects in (3)-(4) reducible to a lack of number markings, or do they reflect a weaker form of identificationality in Vietnamese specificational clauses?

2.4.2 The distribution of *là*

The morpheme *là* appears across several constructions discussed in this paper: predicational clauses, specificational clauses, and cleft-like focus constructions. As noted in Section 2.3, these uses are not clearly distinguished by overt morphology. This overlap makes it difficult to diagnose structure based on form alone.

In addition to the constructions discussed so far, *là* appears in a wider range of environments in Vietnamese. For example, it can also occur in embedding clauses and various (semi-)fixed expressions where its copular meaning is less transparent.

- (25) a. *Embedding clause:*
Nghe nói là Nam mua bánh.
hear say LA N. buy cake
‘It is said that Nam bought the cake.’
b. *Semi-fixed expression:* (from Phan and Duffield 2022)
Nó không học toán là tốt.
3SG NEG study mathematics LA good
‘It’s good that he didn’t study mathematics.’

In the cases mentioned above, *là* either introduces a propositional complement, as in (25-a), or links a clausal constituent to an evaluative predicate, as in (25-b). That is, it does not seem to express an identificational relation but instead functions at the clausal level. These additional uses suggest that *là* is not restricted to one narrowly defined syntactic distribution. Instead, it appears across multiple domains.

2.5 Interim summary

This section has established several background observations relevant to the interpretation of Vietnamese *là*. First, specificational clauses are typically associated with identificational meaning and often give rise to uniqueness effects, though the source and strength of these effects remain questioned. Second, exhaustive focus constructions such as clefts and *only*-sentences involve exclusion of alternatives together with a structured partition between focus and background.

The discussion of Vietnamese *là* suggests that these properties do not uniformly pattern together. On the one hand, Vietnamese specificational clauses allow additive continuations that are typically excluded in English, indicating weaker or more defeasible uniqueness effects. On the other hand, cleft-like *là* constructions behave more like canonical exhaustive focus constructions, strongly excluding alternatives and requiring a more explicit focus-background configuration.

At the same time, Vietnamese differs from canonical cleft systems in lacking overt relative morphology and in using the same morpheme *là* across predicational, specificational, cleft-like, and clausal environments. The resulting overlap makes it difficult to sharply separate these constructions morphosyntactically, despite their interpretive differences.

The two properties of Vietnamese also sharpen the central question of whether the weaker uniqueness effects in specificational *là* reflect nominal underspecification or a deeper interpretive difference.

Taken together, these observations motivate a comparative approach. If Vietnamese specificational and cleft-like *là* differ in how they encode identification and exclusion, then these differences should emerge systematically across diagnostics involving additive continuation, focus sensitivity, negation, and contextual licensing.

3 Empirical description of Vietnamese *là*

3.1 Specificational *là*

Specificational clauses in Vietnamese involve a pre-*là* nominal that introduces a role or variable, and a post-*là* that supplies its value.

(26) (repeated from (3))

Giáo viên là Nam.
teacher LA N.

‘The teacher is Nam.’

As established in Section 2.1, the sentence in (26) instantiates a variable-value configuration. A crucial difference from English becomes apparent when we examine additive continuations.

In English, specificational clauses strongly resist the introduction of an additional value, which reflects the strong uniqueness implication typically seen with specificational clauses. In Vietnamese, however, the corresponding continuation is noticeably more acceptable.

(27) (repeated from (4))

?Giáo viên là Nam, và cũng là Lan.
teacher LA N. and also LA L.

‘The teachers are Nam and Lan.’

The sentence in (27) is not categorically excluded and can be interpreted as introducing multiple individuals that satisfy the relevant role. This contrasts with English, where such continuations are systematically degraded.

A further restriction emerges when the continuation involves a predication clause rather than another (reduced) specificational clause. Unlike in (27), where both conjuncts share the same specificational structure, the sentence in (28) combines a specificational clause with a predication clause and is infelicitous.

(28) #Giáo viên là Nam, và Lan cũng là giáo viên.
teacher LA N. and L. also LA teacher
Intended: ‘The teacher is Nam, but Lan is also a teacher.’

This suggests that the availability of additive interpretations is sensitive to both the presence of multiple values and the structural form in which those values are introduced. In other words, Vietnamese specificational *là* does not freely allow plurality; rather, it permits multiple-value interpretations only under restricted structural conditions, and mismatch configurations are not allowed.

3.2 Cleft-like *là*

Cleft-like *là* constructions involve a focused constituent appearing before *là*, followed by a predicate that expresses the background proposition. In (29), the sentence conveys that Nam is the only individual in the relevant set for whom the proposition holds.

(29) (repeated from (15))

Mỗi Nam là mua bánh.
only N. LA buy cake

‘It is only Nam who bought the cake.’

Applying the same diagnostic as in Section 3.1, cleft-like *là* constructions strongly reject additive continuation. Unlike the specificational case in (27), the continuation in (30) is definitely degraded, reflecting the strong exclusion effect associated with the focused con-

stituent.

- (30) #Mỗi Nam là mua bánh, và Lan cũng vậy.
 only N. LA buy cake and L. also so
 Intended: ‘Only Nam and Lan bought the cake.’ (lit. ‘#Only Nam bought the cake, and Lan too.’)

The contrast between (27) and (30) indicates that cleft-like *là* enforces a stronger form of exhaustivity than specificational *là*. In particular, additive continuation is prohibited when the pre-*là* constituent is interpreted as the unique value among a set of alternatives. This pattern closely parallels the behaviour of *only*-sentences and canonical clefts in languages such as English.

In summary, cleft-like *là* differ systematically from specificational *là* in the strength of their exclusion effects. While specificational clauses allow additive continuation and thus exhibit weaker uniqueness, cleft-like constructions impose stronger exhaustivity and resist the introduction of alternative values.

3.3 Additional diagnostics

The contrast established above can be further tested using two additional diagnostics: compatibility with *mỗi* ‘only’ and the scope of negation.

Cleft-like *là* constructions readily allow *mỗi* ‘only’ in the pre-*là* position, as in (29). However, placing *mỗi* ‘only’ in a specificational configuration is ungrammatical.

- (31) *Giáo viên là mỗi Nam.
 teacher LA only N.
 Intended: ‘The only teacher is Nam.’ (lit. ‘The teacher is only Nam.’)

The infelicity in (31) indicates that the exclusion effect in cleft-like constructions is structurally aligned with the focused constituent, whereas specificational *là* does not provide the same environment for *only*-type interpretation.

A second diagnostic concerns the interpretation of negation. In cleft-like constructions, negation can give rise to multiple readings. The sentence in (32) can be interpreted either as negating the identification (‘someone else bought the cake’) or negating the event (‘Nam did not buy the cake.’)

- (32) Không phải là Nam mua bánh.
 NEG right LA N. buy cake
 Reading 1: ‘It wasn’t Nam who bought the cake.’ (negating the identification)
 Reading 2: ‘It’s not true that Nam bought the cake.’ (negating the event)

In specificational clauses, however, negation is more restricted. Here in (33), negation targets

the identificational relation only.

- (33) Giáo viên không phải là Nam.
teacher NEG right la N.
'The teacher is not Nam.'

These tests provide independent evidence that the two constructions differ in how exclusion effects are encoded. The availability of an event-negation reading in cleft-like constructions but not in specificational ones further supports the view that cleft-like *là* encodes a stronger, more compositionally embedded form of exclusion.

A further puzzle arises when the distribution of *mỗi* 'only' is considered alongside the cleft-like data. As shown in (31), *mỗi* cannot appear post-*là* in a specificational configuration. Yet in cleft-like constructions such as (29), *mỗi* appears pre-*là* in a fronted position and yields a fully acceptable exhaustive interpretation. This asymmetry raises two analytical possibilities. First, Vietnamese may allow exhaustivity to be encoded in two structurally distinct positions — an in-situ position within the predicate domain, as in ordinary non-cleft *only*-constructions, and a left-peripheral focus position, as in cleft-like *là* constructions — such that the two structures are not derivationally related. On this view, the fronted cleft-like configuration cannot simply be derived by moving the in-situ *only* to a higher position, since the two constructions differ in their discourse licensing conditions (cf. Section 2.3.3).

Second, the grammatical status of *là* in cleft-like constructions may reflect an intermediate stage of grammaticalization, in which *là* has shifted from a copular linker to a focus-background partitioning marker. Under this view, Vietnamese cleft-like constructions would represent a distinct construction type that requires its own analysis, rather than a surface variant of ordinary exhaustive focus. Distinguishing between these possibilities is left for future formal work, but the distributional facts presented here suggest that a uniform derivational account of Vietnamese exhaustive focus is unlikely to succeed.

3.4 The role of number neutrality

A potential explanation for the weaker uniqueness effects observed with specificational *là* is that Vietnamese lacks obligatory number marking. Since bare nouns do not encode singular-plural distinctions, sentences such as (26) do not explicitly restrict the domain to a single individual. On this view, the apparent availability of multiple-value interpretations could be attributed to number neutrality rather than to differences in the semantics of identificational constructions.

However, several observations suggest that number neutrality alone cannot account for the contrast between specificational and cleft-like *là*. First, cleft-like constructions such as (29) display strong exclusion effects despite involving the same nominal system. They unambiguously exclude alternative individuals, indicating that the absence of plural marking does not prevent the expression of strong exhaustivity.

Furthermore, as shown in Section 3.1, the availability of multiple-value interpretations in

specificational clauses is restricted and sensitive to structural conditions. Additive continuation is only marginally acceptable when the same specificational format is maintained, and degraded when a different structure (e.g., predication) is introduced. This suggests that the effect is not simply a byproduct of nominal underspecification. If number neutrality were responsible for the weaker uniqueness effects, cleft-like constructions should show similar flexibility. However, they consistently enforce strong exclusion. The structural sensitivity shown in Section 3.1, where only same-format continuations are acceptable, suggests the effect has an interpretive rather than a morphological source.

4 Broader implications

The empirical patterns described in Section 3 raise broader questions about how exhaustivity, uniqueness, and identificationality should be understood, both within Vietnamese and cross-linguistically. While this paper has not provided a full formal analysis, the data nonetheless support several general implications.

First, many approaches to exhaustivity assume a relatively strong exclusion of alternatives, comparable to the contribution of *only*. The Vietnamese data suggest that this notion may need to be refined. In particular, Vietnamese specificational *là* supports identificational interpretations without consistently enforcing strict singleton uniqueness. This indicates that identificationality does not necessarily entail strong exclusion of alternatives, and exhaustivity effects may vary in strength across constructions.

Second, the contrast between English and Vietnamese specificational clauses raises questions about the cross-linguistic generality of commonly assumed properties of specification. While English specificational clauses typically yield strong uniqueness effects, the Vietnamese data show that identificationality does not entail strong exhaustivity. As a result, the link between specificational structure and singleton uniqueness is not universal, and the interpretation of specificational clauses may depend on language-specific factors beyond nominal number marking. Crucially, this gap cannot be attributed to number neutrality (cf. Section 3.4).

Third, Vietnamese also contributes to broader discussions of cleft constructions. Vietnamese cleft-like constructions extend the cross-linguistic picture by showing that focus-background partitioning need not be morphosyntactically explicit. At the same time, the shared use of *là* across copular, cleft-like, and clausal environments indicates that these constructions are not cleanly separated morphosyntactically. This overlap is consistent with the idea that boundaries between constructions involving *là* are gradient rather than categorical.

The Vietnamese data also suggest that exhaustive interpretations are tied to information-structural configuration rather than to exhaustivity alone. This has broader theoretical implications: if cleft-like constructions can be distinguished from ordinary *only*-in-situ constructions not by their exclusion of alternatives but by how explicitly they partition focus from background, then exhaustivity and focus structure must be treated as separable dimensions of meaning.

Lastly, taken together, these patterns emphasize the importance of cross-linguistic variation

in the study of exhaustivity and identification. Languages appear to differ in how strongly identificational constructions enforce exclusion of alternatives, and how clearly different constructions are distinguished morphosyntactically. Vietnamese is particularly informative because it combines number-neutral nominals with a multifunctional element that appears across copular, focus-related, and clausal environments, while simultaneously exhibiting cleft-like focus configurations without overt relativization morphology.

5 Conclusion

This paper has examined the behaviour of Vietnamese *là* in specificational and cleft-like constructions, with the goal of providing a careful empirical description of how these constructions differ in their interpretation. The main puzzle concerns the relationship between identificationality and uniqueness: while specificational clauses in languages such as English typically give rise to strong singleton interpretations, Vietnamese displays a weaker pattern.

The empirical findings can be summarized as follows. First, Vietnamese specificational *là* expresses an identificational relation but does not consistently enforce strict singleton uniqueness. Additive continuation is marginally possible under restricted structural conditions, indicating that multiple-value interpretations are not categorically excluded. Second, cleft-like *là* constructions exhibit strong exclusion effects, behaving similarly to *only*-type interpretations and resisting additive continuation. Third, additional diagnostics, including *only*-compatibility and negation scope, confirm that the two constructions differ systematically in how exclusion is encoded. Finally, the contrast cannot be reduced to number neutrality alone, as strong exhaustivity remains available in cleft-like constructions within the same nominal system.

Taken together, these observations show that identificationality and strong uniqueness are not obligatorily linked together in Vietnamese. Instead, different *là* constructions lead to distinct interpretive patterns, suggesting that exhaustivity is not a uniform phenomenon even within a language. In particular, cleft-like *là* constructions display a more explicit focus-background partition and stronger dependence on discourse-salient alternatives than ordinary non-cleft exhaustive focus constructions, despite lacking the overt morphology typically associated with canonical clefts. Vietnamese thus provides a productive test case for refining cross-linguistic theories of identification and exhaustivity.

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